

Clock Watching

SÈME · FICTION · DESCRIPTIVE STORY · 314 WORDS

NAME: _____ DATE: _____

Many who pass through this immense, majestic train station take an occasional glance in my direction. I, meanwhile, have been observing them all for years from my bird’s-eye perspective. I, you see, am an oversized clock perched high upon the wall.

At the moment, my hour hand is on the 10 and my minute hand is on the 12. That means the morning rush hour is winding down. But the concourse is still an obstacle course of scurrying people – some zig-zagging alone in the hall, others in pairs or groups. There’s the usual assortment of commuters, looking purposeful or befuddled, harried or calm. They scoot past each other, not making eye contact, or bump into one another and apologise. They stop and chat. They assist one another by retrieving dropped papers or luggage. It’s the same old bustling scene that plays out here every weekday.

In a short while, the station will calm down enough for me to focus on what I really like watching – the entertainment. That’s a part of life here that frequently does change. Of the collection of clowns, jugglers, musician and others that call this great hall their stage, my favourites are the people in costume. It warms my clock heart to see their plastic buckets fill with change.

I still fondly remember the guy dressed as Big Ben. His costume looked like the famed clock tower complete with chimes that rang on the hour. Sadly, he found another stage. This month’s crowd favourite seems to be the Statue of Liberty, right now encircled by onlookers seemingly bewitched by every slight, silent tilt of her crowned, green head. Ah, but what’s this I see – a newcomer? Yes, it’s a dancing hot dog coated with mustard. This fellow is siphoning away some of the statue’s gawkers. Maybe people are hungrier than they know. Oh, I love this station.

A · ANNOTATE THE TEXT

1. Underline in the passage the words that match this — **POINT OF VIEW**

Find the line that finally reveals *what* the narrator actually is.

2. Underline in the passage the words that match this — **VOCABULARY**

Find the pair of opposites that helps you work out what *befuddled* means.

3. Underline in the passage the words that match this — **WORD CHOICE**

Find where *change* is used to mean coins rather than things altering.

4. Underline in the passage the words that match this — **VOCABULARY**

Find the earlier word that means almost the same as *gawkers*.

5. Underline in the passage the words that match this — **VOCABULARY**

Find the phrase showing that the hot dog is slowly pulling the crowd away from the statue.

B · READING QUESTIONS

6. “But the concourse is still an obstacle course of scurrying people.” What is the concourse? **VOCABULARY IN CONTEXT**

- ☐ A The rush of travellers hurrying to catch their morning trains
- ☐ B The large open hall that people cross inside the station
- ☐ C The raised walkway the clock is fixed to, high above the floor
- ☐ D A quieter side room where the street performers set up their stage

7. “...looking purposeful or befuddled, harried or calm.” What does “befuddled” mean? **VOCABULARY**

- ☐ A Relaxed and quite untroubled about the journey that lies ahead
- ☐ B Confused, the opposite of knowing just where you are going
- ☐ C Travelling alone rather than in one of the pairs or groups
- ☐ D Rushed and flustered, with barely any time at all to spare

8. The word “change” appears twice in the third paragraph. How do the two uses differ? **WORD CHOICE**

- ☐ A The first is about the performers; the second is about the earlier commuters
- ☐ B The first means coins given by the crowd; the second means the acts altering
- ☐ C The first means things altering; the second means coins
- ☐ D The first hints at coins; the second hints at the seasons turning outside

9. How does the narrator’s position affect what it can tell us? **POINT OF VIEW**

- ☐ A Set above the doors, it can watch the trains and the streets outside as well
- ☐ B Fixed high on one wall, it sees the whole hall but never leaves this one spot
- ☐ C Perched up high, it can follow its favourite performers home once they finish
- ☐ D High above the crowd, it can catch every private word the commuters exchange

10. Which word in the final paragraph helps you most to work out what “gawkers” means? **VOCABULARY**

- ☐ A “onlookers”, used a few lines earlier for the very same crowd
- ☐ B “newcomer”, used just before the dancing hot dog is described
- ☐ C “bewitched”, which describes how that watching crowd feels
- ☐ D “favourite”, used for the performer the crowd gathers around

11. Which sentence best sums up what happens in this text? **SUMMARY**

- A** One performer the clock recalls fondly was a man dressed as Big Ben, in a costume so complete that it even chimed on the hour.
- B** Big, grand old railway stations in the heart of a busy city are really far too loud and crowded for anyone at all to enjoy lingering in them for very long on any ordinary weekday morning.
- C** The clock reads its own hands, hour on the 10 and minute on the 12, and works out that the morning rush hour is slowly winding down.
- D** A station clock describes the weekday crowds passing below it, then turns to the costumed street performers it most enjoys watching, including a dancing hot dog who has just arrived.

C • EVIDENCE VS CLAIM

12. This quote is evidence that... **EVIDENCE VS CLAIM**

“an obstacle course of scurrying people”

- A** The commuters are taking part in some kind of organised race
- B** The station has set up barriers that block the way across the hall
- C** The hall has almost emptied, so people stroll straight across it
- D** The hall is so crowded that crossing it takes effort and dodging

13. This quote is evidence that... **EVIDENCE VS CLAIM**

“looking purposeful or befuddled, harried or calm”

- A** The clock is naming four real people it has come to know well
- B** The commuters are sorted into pairs of opposite types
- C** All of the commuters are late and panicking about their trains
- D** Every commuter in the hall is feeling one and the same way

14. This quote is evidence that... **EVIDENCE VS CLAIM**

“encircled by onlookers seemingly bewitched”

- A** The onlookers truly believe real magic is happening before them
- B** The performer holds her audience perfectly still and spellbound
- C** The performer moves fast and boldly to keep the crowd amused
- D** The crowd is growing bored and drifting towards the station exits

15. This quote is evidence that... **EVIDENCE VS CLAIM**

“This fellow is siphoning away some of the statue’s gawkers”

- A** The newcomer has pulled the whole crowd off the statue at once
- B** The two performers have teamed up to share the coins they earn
- C** The statue performer has given up and gone to find a new stage
- D** The newcomer is gradually drawing part of the crowd away

D • BEST EXPLANATION

16. Which explanation proves the claim best? **BEST EXPLANATION**

CLAIM

The writer delays telling us what the narrator is.

“I, you see, am an oversized clock perched high upon the wall”

- A** The narrator explains that it is a large clock which has been fixed high up on the wall of the busy train station, and that it has been quietly watching the travellers below for many years now.
- B** This proves that the writer forgot to explain who the narrator was and had to add the information in late.
- C** The story tells us something surprising about who is speaking at the end of the first paragraph of the text.
- D** Two sentences pass before the reveal, so the reader first pictures a person watching; the correction then makes “bird’s-eye perspective” and years of watching suddenly fit.

17. Which explanation proves the claim best? **BEST EXPLANATION**

CLAIM

Opposites in the sentence give away the meaning of a hard word.

“looking purposeful or befuddled, harried or calm”

- A** The writer uses some words in this sentence that a reader of this age might not already know well.
- B** The words arrive in contrasting pairs, so “befuddled” must be the opposite of “purposeful”; the sentence quietly defines a difficult word without ever stopping to explain it.
- C** The commuters walking through the station hall are described using four different words in the second paragraph, which comes shortly after the clock tells us the morning rush hour is winding down.
- D** This proves that all four of these words mean roughly the same thing, since they appear in one list together.

18. Which explanation proves the claim best? **BEST EXPLANATION**

CLAIM

One word is made to carry two different meanings.

“plastic buckets fill with change”

- A** “Change” meant altering a few lines earlier and means coins here; only the words around it decide which, and the bucket is what settles it.
- B** The writer uses the same word more than once within a single paragraph of the story.
- C** This proves the performers are paid by the station itself rather than by the members of the public who watch them.
- D** People passing through the great hall drop coins into the plastic buckets that the costumed street performers have left out on the floor beside them for that purpose.